

Task Force to Reimagine Policing in Brookline Meeting Minutes

April 23, 2021 | 8:00 a.m.

*Meeting held remotely on Zoom due to COVID-19; hosted by Town Staff Devon Fields, meeting
Chaired by Raul Fernandez.*

Members Present:

Raul Fernandez
Anne Weaver
Alexander Weinstein
Almas Dossa
Bonnie Bastien
Kimberley Richardson
Kristan Singleton
Malcolm Cawthorne
Mike Sandman
Chi Chi Wu
Eitan Hersh

Non-Voting Members Present:

Dan O’Leary, former Police Chief, and Department Task Force Liaison
Michael Downey, Brookline Assistant Town Counsel
Mel Kleckner, Brookline Town Administrator
Ann Braga, Brookline HR Director

Members/Non-Voting Members Absent:

Lloyd Gellineau, Brookline Office of Diversity, Inclusion and Community Relations Director

Others Present:

John VanScoyoc
Bernard Greene
Marty Rosenthal
Neil Gordon
Valerie Frias
Justin Casanova-Davis
Ronald Wilkinson
Carla Benka

Announcements/Updates

Raul Fernandez opens the meeting acknowledging the verdict in the Derek Chauvin trial. He identifies the murder of George Floyd as a catalyst for this Task Force and movements across the country.

The meeting minutes from April 9, 2021 are unanimously approved.

Discussion of Select Board Votes

- Raul Fernandez gives an overview of the three votes that were put before the Select Board at their meeting on Tuesday, April 20, 2021
- Bonnie Bastien comments that the discussion on their most basic recommendation, for the Police Department to hold 6 public meetings a year, the Select Board decided to pull apart the recommendation and could not achieve a unanimous vote. She said the discussion was frustrating to watch and disappointing.
- Malcolm Cawthorne asks who will make the Select Board accountable in their role as Police Commissioners. He mentions the idea of kid gloves being used around the police and the Select Board needs to step up and give the difficult directives to the Police Department
- Chi Chi Wu says the group needs to continue to push against the narrative of low morale for the police department.
- Bonnie Bastien is disappointed that the public meetings item takes responsibility from the Police Department and puts it on the community engagement specialist who is only one person and is removed from public safety at this early stage in the new position.
- Mel Kleckner identifies the Committee on Policing Reforms will present the survey they sent out to the Police Department at the Select Board meeting on April 27, 2021, but the Select Board will not be taking a vote on the presentation.
- Raul Fernandez identifies that the rest of the recommendations/votes will be taken up after the election on May 4, 2021, and he indicates things could be different with the results on future votes depending on the outcome of the election.
- Malcolm Cawthorne raises questions about the police department survey - what were the motivations, who conducted it, etc. He notes that the world is still in the middle of a global pandemic and morale is low across the board and questions why a special interest should be taken for this particular town department. Mike Sandman says that he thinks the information will be valuable in an effort to change behavior in the Police Department.
- Raul Fernandez confirms that this information will be made publicly available.
- Ronald Wilkinson, member of the Committee on Policing Reforms, is promoted to a panelist to explain the process of how the Police Department personnel survey. He said it was a last minute addition following the lead from the City of Newton. They were specifically looking to get the perspectives of the rank and file members of the

department and think it can inform further reforms/reimagining work moving forward. Malcolm Cawthorne says he trusts the work and the process as Ronald Wilkinson has presented it but Malcolm does not trust the timeline and that it appears that the Reforms Committee has not been on the same deadline schedule as the Task Force and thus been able to get less public comment and exposure.

- Raul Fernandez thanks Ronald Wilkinson for sharing and clarifying. He mentions that while police officers' opinions matter, he notes that the Reforms Committee didn't focus as much on communities of color or strive to get in touch with them/get their perspective as much as they have for the police department.
- Malcolm Cawthorne thanks Ronald Wilkinson. He notes his emphasis on the survey comes from concern about the seemingly continual work of the Reforms Committee that hasn't been documented or presented anywhere clearly or consistently. He asserts the Reforms Committee continues to get bites at the apple while the Task Force has completed their work and are waiting for the deliberation and votes from the Select Board. He mentions a specific instance where the Police Department/Office of Diversity, Inclusion, and Community Relations are doing a survey at the Teen Center which seems to be Reforms Committee work but it is unclear if it is coming from that group, the Police Department or the ODICR.
- Raul Fernandez shares this concern and notes he will share with the Select Board he believes the Reforms Committee's work should end so that decisions can be made.
- Anne Weaver shares concerns about the Teen Center survey work that she's unsure about how the process has come about, the survey questions, how the children will be asked/how the way the questions are posed could change their answers. She would like clarity on how the process is being managed and how it will move forward.
- Bonnie Bastien suggests a meeting on May 7th if there is a budget amendment for Town Meeting on the Brookline Forward proposal.
- Kimberley Richardson requests to circle back to the Teen Center survey and wonders if this will be part of their report. Staff confirms that this will not be part of their formal Reforms Committee report. She identifies that this line of question comes from the impact of the walk and talk program and how it impacts adults and families in the Housing Authority. Why are they targeting the Teen Center for this and not the School Resource Officer issue. Ann Braga says the inspiration for this process was because when they surveyed the BHA residents they didn't hear from young people so they wanted to do a targeted outreach. Bonnie Bastien confirms that they've been struggling with this and trying to impact positive change on this process from the outside. The Walk and Talk subcommittee wants to be sure this is done the right way and that isn't harmful to the teens or the BHA residents as far as what the walk and talk program actually is versus do you know who these officers are and do you like them.
- Malcolm Cawthorne brings up the April 12 School Committee Subcommittee meeting with Sergeant Hatchett mentions work with the Teen Center and he notes that this is part

of the body that is supposed to be informing the work of the Select Board and it doesn't feel like an appropriate approach. Malcolm also mentions departmental lobbying that has happened and how he feels that approach is also inappropriate.

- Chi Chi Wu brings up that the Tufts Survey the Task Force undertook got a lot of scrutiny during the public process and she is wondering if they are going to be able to go back and redo aspects of their work. Will the Reforms Committee survey undergo the same scrutiny?
- Eitan Hersch echoes what Chi Chi Wu states about the survey scrutiny and the process critiques about the Reforms Committee not meeting deadlines. He also emphasizes that the longer this process drags out and the more convoluted it becomes the public will continue to bring this before them making it an ongoing unending process that is never resolved. Raul Fernandez acknowledges this point and notes that some of that can be attributed to the 5 member Select Board leadership as opposed to a Mayor structure.
- Alexander Weinstein requests a date certain in writing when the Reforms Committee will stop their work. He also notes that it doesn't seem to be responsible behavior for a public body to continue working on this when the deadlines have passed.
- Raul Fernandez asks Ann Braga and Mel Kleckner if they can help identify how much money it would take to secure an executive position for a social service arm/agency within the town if this group undertakes a budget amendment. Mel Kleckner says yes the staff can help cost out this expense. He does note that the proposal is intriguing to have an internal person working on the development of that entity and he looks forward to discussing it further. He does mention the Reserve Fund could be a funding source. Mike Sandman notes he doesn't believe money is the issue. He said the Reforms Committee and Task Force should set aside the mistrust and work together to try and pass something like this during the Town Meeting. Raul Fernandez acknowledges this and he mentions that the process has now been one year and while working together has been the goal he wants to see action which will now take place at Town Meeting because the Board isn't meeting until after the Election on these issues.
- Chi Chi Wu emphasizes the trust comment from Mike Sandman but she questions the process which makes this whole thing feel unequal and challenging.
- Raul Fernandez closes by reminding the Task Force that their reimagining proposals and recommendations are strong and had a robust public process in the development and creation process.

The meeting adjourns at 9:50 AM

Martin Rosenthal 09:40 AM

AMEN to MikeS: too much mistrust CPR-TF, & need to (all) work together!

Martin Rosenthal 08:38 AM

MR (1) air fresheners: MAppCt banned that as "impeded operation" in mid-'00's, I think C v Brazeau, while I had a suppression of a gun pending for profiling (New Bedford), later allowed. (2) Chief O decided not to get tasers ~ 10 yrs ago; (3) Publ/Hrgs: barely mentioned was PCAC has to have public comment every mtg, & two annual public hearings ; & there's diminishing returns for them

Answer live

Type answer

Ronald Wilkinson 08:48 AM

I would like to speak to Malcolm's question about the survey of police personnel.

Answer live

Type answer

Martin Rosenthal 09:05 AM

"morale" -- & base salaries (aside from private details that younger cops don't want as much) -- are big issues, not just for keeping good young cops, but also for diversity (also females!) -- also in upper ranks, yes 2 big issues. Young cops leaving is a serious issue.

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Ronald Wilkinson 09:46 AM

The police personnel survey was authorized at the last meeting of the full Reform Committee.

Martin Rosenthal 09:05 AM

✕ Dismiss

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Answer live

Type answer

Ronald Wilkinson 09:36 AM

I heartily agree with Mike's comments about trust!